A Beginner's Guide to Networking

Rakshitha Arni Ravishankar, Harvard Business Review (HBR Ascend), March 22, 2023

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I've always had a love-hate relationship with networking. When I was in college, networking seemed transactional. I disliked the idea of building relationships for my own personal gain and small talk with strangers triggered my social anxiety. As I've grown in my career, however, I've learned that networking doesn't have to be opportunistic.

Yes, networking can help you land jobs and gain access to new opportunities. But it can also be about making genuine connections, knowledge sharing, and giving back to others. It just depends on what you want and how you approach it.

If you're feeling confused, anxious, or unsure about what networking really is, why it matters, and how to get started, here are some pieces of advice from our authors to help you move forward in a way that feels right for you.

Why is networking so important?

A professional network can offer you many things, but perhaps the most talked about, is career growth. Research shows that people with stronger networks end up with higher salaries and more promotions. It makes sense. The more connected you are to people at different job levels, both inside and outside of your organization, the more likely you are to know about new opportunities when they arise. When senior employees within your company know the great work you're doing, the odds of them putting your name in for a promotion increase. The same can be said for people externally. If an employer is hiring for a position that matches your capabilities and ambitions, having the right connection at that company can help you get your resume to the hiring manager.

In addition, when you interact with different people, you're also constantly gathering information. Depending on who you're connected to, you can use your network to get feedback on an important project (talk to your peers), learn insights about your industry (talk to a thought leader on LinkedIn), or even gain tips on how to excel in the culture of your organization (talk to a senior leader on your team). These interactions can result in you learning, growing, and performing at a higher level.

What's an easy way to start networking?

Does networking conjure up images of big, noisy rooms full of strangers? Think again. In her article, "Easy Networking Tips for the Networking Haters," author Amantha Imber shares some useful advice for anyone who hates talking to strangers: The best way to maintain a network is to reconnect with your dormant ties, according to Marissa King, professor of organizational behavior at the Yale School of Management. Dormant ties are people you already know, but that you haven't seen or reached out to in a few years.

Research shows that dormant ties are more likely to provide you with creative advice than a brand new connection. This may be even more likely if you've already built a foundation of trust. Once a week, write down the names of two or three dormant ties. Think of people you felt most connected to in the past, and send them a short message along the lines of, "Hey, I'm thinking about you. How have you been?" Then go from there.

You may have a more specific question for them in mind, but as a first step, focus on getting back in touch.

Is networking all about finding a job?

The short answer to this question is "no." Traditionally, networking has been conflated with attending in-person events, schmoozing, and trying to land a new role. While some people use their networks in this way, others have gotten a bit more creative. In the digital age, networking has become a new way for people to build connections around the world, exchange knowledge, and get to know others on a deeper level. Here are a couple of ways to reframe your thinking around networking.

1) Remember that networking can be about helping others.

If networking feels too transactional for you, consider using it to offer your knowledge, skills, advice, or expertise to other people — even when you don't need or want something in return. This can help you connect with people on a deeper level, according to Professor Deborah Grayson Riegel. In her article, "Are You Taking Full Advantage of Your Network?", Riegal talks about how to develop your "help fluency," or the range of ways you can be helpful to others.

Think about what you're good at, what you like to do, and what others often ask you to assist them with. For instance, if you're a great proofreader, you can offer to help copyedit a connection's resume and cover letter. Or if you're a great listener, you can support a connection who might be going through a difficult time.

2) There's more to networking than "small talk."

If you hate small talk, here's some good news: Research shows that most people prefer intimate conversations, even if they're meeting you for the first time. In fact, deep conversations are correlated with higher levels of happiness and make people feel more connected with each other.

In the article, "A Better Approach to Networking," author Christie Hunter Arscott shares a few examples of conversation starters you can use to avoid boring small talk.

Instead of: What do you do?

Try: What do you think is the most valuable part of your work — to yourself and others? What problems do you want to help others solve? What aspects of your work do you enjoy most and why? What do you enjoy least and why?

Instead of: What is your current role?

Ask: What roles and positions have led you to where you are today? Which ones taught you the most?

Instead of: Where are you from?

Ask: What places have you lived in and traveled to through your career or studies? Which ones have had the biggest impact on you? Which was your favorite and why?

How do you get better at networking?

Now that you know why networking matters, and a few ways to go about it, here are some tips to help you jump in and meet people.

1) Determine what you want to learn.

If you want to make new connections, but aren't sure where to start, focus on finding people who you can learn from. Begin by seeking out "lateral connections" within your organization, or people who are at your same job level. They could be peers on your team, or people in other departments who are working on projects that you're curious about.

In her article, "How to Strengthen Your Network When You're Just Starting Out," author Holly Raider explains that lateral connections can not only teach you new skills, but they can also give you a more varied outlook on the organization, help shape your performance, and provide you access to opportunities in different areas of the company.

For example, let's say that you're a sales associate looking to sharpen your skills. Consider connecting with a coordinator on the product development team. This will give you insight into new innovations that the team is working on, and allow you to understand the personal stories behind them. You can then use that information to improve your sales pitch. Likewise, the coordinator can learn from you about what customers really want, and design better products based on your feedback.

2) Build relationships at all levels.

Connecting with your peers is a great place to start, but if you're looking for growth opportunities, you also need to connect with people above you. I'm not just referring to your manager. Of course, having a good relationship with your boss will make life easier, but experts say that your career growth will be faster if you invest in relationships across different levels within (and beyond) your organization. Author Jenny Wood, in her article, "Why Managing Up to Your Boss Is Not Enough," writes, "When people of influence know you, they can advocate for you, offer you high-profile projects, and support your career goals." Here are a few ways to put this advice into practice:

Reach out to your boss's boss. Review your recent projects with them, learn about their priorities, and explain what customers are saying on the ground. This can help give them a "fresh-eyes" perspective and will lead them to think of you should a new project or opportunity arise.

Reach out to your manager's peers. Are there managers or leaders in other departments that you could collaborate with? Working with a new manager and getting their feedback can be an effective way to show off your skills and talents, and establish another advocate for your performance during promotions and appraisals.

Reach out to external leaders. Always look for connections outside your team and company — they can help you when it's time for your next move.

3) Focus on your value.

How do you actually connect with someone more senior than you? Highlight the unique skills and knowledge you can offer them. In his article, "How to Network in the Age of Remote Work," author Duncan Wardle writes, "As digital natives, many Gen Z employees underestimate how valuable their knowledge of new trends and innovations may be. A great way to earn respect is to establish yourself as an expert on a trending topic."

If you're passionate about technology and believe that your company could benefit from a new development, for example, reach out to a senior leader with your idea. Set up a monthly catch-up and use the time to give them an overview of the new tech and how it could benefit the business.

You can also create a Slack channel where you post regularly, or share articles and posts relevant to your area of interest or expertise. Once you establish yourself as a subject matter expert, leaders inside your company will take notice and may even begin asking for your input or advice.

4) When reaching out to someone externally, be clear with your request.

If you're looking to connect with people outside of your organization, LinkedIn is a great place to begin. You can connect with new people online, and overstep the anxiety of attending a networking event in-person.

Whether you're looking for advice on your career path, trying to find a mentor, or want someone to review your resume, the way you frame your message will determine whether or not you receive a response. In her article, "What to Say When You're Reaching Out to Someone on LinkedIn," author Kristi DePaul recommends avoiding vague questions like, "Can I pick your brain?" Instead, get right to the point — quickly share who you are, how you found this person, and what you're looking for. Try saying something along the lines of:

> [Name],
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> Your professional journey really stood out to me. I'm very interested in building my career as a [role]. Since you have a great deal of experience in that position, I was wondering if you might have some time to offer me a bit of advice around how to pursue it. I'm curious how you got to where you are today. I would really appreciate a brief call at your convenience.
>
> Let me know if you're open to chatting?

5) Networking is not always inclusive. You can change that.

People from marginalized communities are often given the advice to "network for better opportunities." However, the unfortunate reality is that white, more privileged groups continue to control access to the majority of jobs and career opportunities.

AiLun Ku and Ray Reyes in their article, "Networking as a First-Generation Student Can Be Hard. Here's How to Get Started," explain that every society has a dominant culture. When you're not from the dominant culture, the things that make you "different" — your skin color, economic status, family history, heritage, and culture — can feel like shortcomings. But they're not.

For instance, if you're an immigrant with parents who run their own business, you likely speak more than one language, can navigate between different cultures, and have helped your parents with their day-to-day work. Your cultural competence and business acumen are skills you've learned throughout your life — these qualities set you apart.

Before networking, ask yourself: What are my strengths? What skills have I learned from my life experiences that I can put to practice? How can I turn them into a story that shows I'm the best person for this company, role, promotion, etc.?

Ku and Reyes conclude: "Becoming aware of your strengths as a person — beyond formal education — will enable you to network confidently and present yourself as the missing piece to an employer's hiring puzzle."

While networking may feel challenging at first, know that it's a skill you can learn (and hone) over time. All you need is a little practice. Use networking as an opportunity to learn about yourself, help others, and build deeper, more genuine connections with people who can expand your worldview. Now, go get started.

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